

Notes: Serra-Garcia (AER, 2026)

The Attention-Information Trade-Off

Contents

1	Big picture	3
2	Data and measurement	3
2.1	Sender experiment: professionals and treatments	3
2.2	Scientific articles used as source material	4
2.3	Accuracy outcomes	4
2.4	Focus outcomes	4
2.5	Style outcomes	5
2.6	Receiver experiments	5
2.7	Receiver outcomes	5
3	Empirical specifications and theoretical logic	6
3.1	Sender-side treatment effects	6
3.2	Receiver-side exposure effects	6
3.3	Overall knowledge decomposition	6
3.4	Missing information versus distorted information	7
3.5	Heterogeneity in clicks and knowledge	7
4	Identification and empirical design	7
4.1	What identifies the sender effects	7
4.2	What identifies the receiver effects	7
4.3	Why the click design is useful	8
4.4	Why the paper is not just about misinformation	8
4.5	Limits and external validity	8
5	Tables and figures	8
5.1	Figure 1 and Figure 2: source articles and receiver design	8
5.2	Figure 3 and Table 1: effects on sender summaries	9
5.3	Figure 4 and Figure 5: online headlines and LLM senders	10
5.4	Table 2 and Figure 6: receiver knowledge and clicks	11
5.5	Figure 7 and Figure 8: errors, beliefs, and intentions	12
5.6	Figure 9: heterogeneity in attention and knowledge	13
6	Short summary	14
7	Conclusion	15
7.1	Core conclusion	15
7.2	Economic intuition	15

7.3 Takeaway	15
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1 Big picture

- **Question.** How does information transmission change when content producers must attract the attention of receivers?
- **Core trade-off.** Attention incentives can increase demand for information, but they can also reduce the amount of information in the initial content. The paper studies this attention-information trade-off experimentally.
- **Setting.** Freelance professional writers produce short summaries of scientific findings on cancer, sleep, vaccines, and climate. Their incentives are randomized: inform readers, generate clicks, or generate content expected to be shared virally.
- **Sender experiment.** The sender experiment hires 149 freelance professionals on Fiverr and collects 595 summaries. Each summary contains a headline and a three-sentence description.
- **Receiver experiments.** Separate online receiver experiments expose participants to the generated summaries and measure knowledge, click demand for more information, recall, errors, and downstream beliefs or intentions.
- **Main sender result.** Clickbait and viral incentives reduce accurate information in the summaries and increase content not present in the scientific materials. They do *not* significantly increase explicitly inaccurate descriptions of the original materials.
- **Focus result.** Attention incentives shift summaries away from methods and findings and toward introductions, relevance, and calls to action. This creates information gaps rather than necessarily direct falsehoods.
- **Style result.** Attention incentives make summaries shorter, more readable, and more attention-grabbing, with more punctuation such as exclamation marks and questions.
- **Receiver knowledge result.** When receivers only see summaries, their knowledge is lower under clickbait and viral incentives. When they can click, attention incentives increase click rates and partially offset knowledge losses.
- **Misperception result.** Among receivers who do not demand more information, missing details can create biased beliefs. Receivers are more likely to think study samples are representative and more likely to infer behavioral prescriptions.
- **LLM result.** GPT-3.5 summaries display qualitatively similar patterns: attention incentives reduce accuracy and focus indices while increasing attention-grabbing style.
- **Economic takeaway.** Online attention incentives need not produce more factually false statements. They can instead generate misperceptions through selective, vague, and relevance-focused communication that omits important scientific details.

2 Data and measurement

2.1 Sender experiment: professionals and treatments

- Freelance professionals were recruited from Fiverr in writing-related categories such as social media copy and research summaries.
- The sample contains 149 professionals and 595 summaries. Each professional writes summaries about research articles, producing short social-media-style communication.
- The scientific topics are public-interest research findings in four areas: cancer, sleep, vaccines, and climate.
- The three randomized incentive treatments are:

- **Info-incentives:** provide accurate information; bonus depends on a reader answering questions correctly.
- **Clickbait-incentives:** stimulate readers to click to learn more; bonus depends on reader click behavior.
- **Viral-incentives:** produce a summary likely to be shared virally; bonus depends on perceived social-media shareability.
- The content given to senders includes abstracts, press-release-style materials, and access to the full paper.

Interpretation: The sender design isolates the supply-side effect of attention incentives: the same underlying scientific materials are communicated under different payoff motives.

2.2 Scientific articles used as source material

- Eight articles are used: two on cancer, two on sleep, two on vaccines, and two on climate.
- The articles are chosen from research that received broader public attention, including studies featured in the New York Times.
- The source materials have a common structure: introduction, method, finding, and conclusion.
- This common structure allows the paper to classify what information is transmitted and what is omitted.

Interpretation: The scientific article design gives a ground truth for coding accuracy. The experiment is not merely measuring whether content sounds persuasive; it compares content to a known underlying information set.

2.3 Accuracy outcomes

Each summary is divided into information units. A unit is a single identifiable statement, often a sentence or clause. Each unit is coded as:

- **Accurate-in text:** correctly describes information present in the materials.
- **Inaccurate-in text:** wrongly or incompletely describes information present in the materials.
- **Not in text:** introduces information not provided in the materials.

The paper summarizes accuracy with an index in which accurate information increases the index and inaccurate or not-in-text information decreases the index.

$$AccuracyIndex_{sa} = A_{sa}^{accurate} - A_{sa}^{inaccurate} - A_{sa}^{not\ in\ text} \quad \text{after standardization and index construction.}$$

Interpretation: This coding separates direct factual inaccuracy from missing-information mechanisms. Attention incentives may mislead without making more explicitly false claims.

2.4 Focus outcomes

Information units are also classified by focus:

- introduction or motivation;
- method or sample details;
- findings;
- conclusion or implication;

- call to action.

The focus index rewards detailed scientific information and penalizes broader framing:

$$FocusIndex_{sa} = Method_{sa} + Finding_{sa} - Introduction_{sa} - Conclusion_{sa} - CTA_{sa} \quad \text{after standardization.}$$

Interpretation: The key question is whether attention incentives shift summaries from scientific detail to context, relevance, and exhortation.

2.5 Style outcomes

- **Length:** word count.
- **Readability:** Flesch Reading Ease Score.
- **Sentiment:** tone of the text.
- **Punctuation:** use of exclamation marks, question marks, ellipses, hashtags, icons, or emojis.

The style index is high when a summary is more attention-grabbing:

$$StyleIndex_{sa} = -Words_{sa} + Readability_{sa} - Sentiment_{sa} + Punctuation_{sa} \quad \text{after standardization.}$$

Interpretation: The style measures capture the presentation channel: even if the factual content were unchanged, senders could attract attention by making text shorter, easier, and more arousing.

2.6 Receiver experiments

- Receiver experiments are run on Prolific with US participants.
- Participants are exposed to summaries generated in the sender experiment.
- The paper separates knowledge measurement from attention allocation by using both no-click and click designs.
- In knowledge experiments, receivers see summaries and answer questions with summaries available or after recall.
- In click experiments, receivers choose whether to click for additional information; click implementation is probabilistic to reduce selection concerns.
- Across receiver experiments with professional summaries, 3,743 participants are exposed to summaries.

Interpretation: The receiver experiments identify how the sender-side content changes affect downstream attention, knowledge, and beliefs under controlled exposure.

2.7 Receiver outcomes

- **Summary-based knowledge:** correctness after reading only the short summary.
- **Click rate:** whether a receiver chooses to obtain additional information.
- **Materials-based knowledge:** correctness after reading detailed materials.
- **Overall knowledge:** weighted knowledge combining summary-only and clicked cases.

- **Errors:** whether incorrect answers exaggerate sample size or representativeness.
- **Beliefs and intentions:** whether receivers infer official doctor recommendations, encourage others, or intend behavior change.

Interpretation: The paper’s central idea is not just that attention incentives change content. It measures how the changed content affects what people know and believe.

3 Empirical specifications and theoretical logic

3.1 Sender-side treatment effects

For sender summary outcome Y_{sa} , where s indexes sender-summary observations and a indexes articles, the core specification is:

$$Y_{sa} = \alpha_a + \beta_C \text{Clickbait}_s + \beta_V \text{Viral}_s + \gamma' X_s + \delta \text{Wave}_s + \varepsilon_{sa}.$$

- α_a are article fixed effects.
- Clickbait_s and Viral_s are indicators for the randomized sender incentives.
- X_s denotes sender characteristics when included.
- β_C and β_V measure how attention incentives alter the supply of communication relative to Info-incentives.

Interpretation: A negative β_C or β_V on the accuracy or focus index means attention incentives reduce information transmission relative to the accurate-information benchmark.

3.2 Receiver-side exposure effects

For receiver outcome Y_{ir} after exposure to summary r , the core receiver specification can be written as:

$$Y_{ir} = \alpha_a + \beta_C \text{Clickbait}_r + \beta_V \text{Viral}_r + \theta' Z_i + u_{ir}.$$

- Y_{ir} may be knowledge, click choice, error type, belief, or intention.
- Treatment is inherited from the incentive under which the exposed summary was written.
- α_a controls for the underlying scientific article.
- The key estimates ask how changed communication affects receivers.

Interpretation: Receiver random assignment separates content effects from receiver selection. It asks what happens when people are exogenously exposed to summaries written under different incentive regimes.

3.3 Overall knowledge decomposition

The attention-information trade-off can be summarized as:

$$K_{ir}^{\text{overall}} = (1 - \text{Click}_{ir}) K_{ir}^{\text{summary}} + \text{Click}_{ir} K_{ir}^{\text{materials}}.$$

- Attention incentives can reduce K^{summary} because the summary contains less information.
- They can increase Click because the summary is more attention-grabbing.
- If clicked materials are informative, they can increase $K^{\text{materials}}$ among clickers.

Interpretation: Average overall knowledge depends on the size of both effects: information loss among non-clickers and information gain among clickers.

3.4 Missing information versus distorted information

The paper distinguishes two mechanisms:

Distorted information: $\Delta InaccurateInText > 0$,

Missing information: $\Delta AccurateInText < 0$ and $\Delta NotInText > 0$.

Interpretation: The paper finds stronger evidence for missing information than for directly inaccurate information. This matters because fact-checking systems often target false statements, while omissions and vague relevance claims are harder to police.

3.5 Heterogeneity in clicks and knowledge

The summary-level heterogeneity regression can be represented as:

$$Knowledge_m = \alpha + \lambda ClickRate_m + \eta_a + e_m,$$

where m indexes messages. Figure 9 shows that higher click rates are associated with lower summary-based knowledge, but the relationship is much weaker for overall knowledge after clickers receive more information.

Interpretation: The best attention-grabbing summaries can create information demand. But among people who do not click, the same summaries can transmit less knowledge.

4 Identification and empirical design

4.1 What identifies the sender effects

- Sender incentives are randomly assigned across professionals.
- The underlying scientific materials are held fixed.
- Coders who classify summary content are blind to sender incentives.
- Article fixed effects compare summaries about the same underlying scientific finding.

Interpretation: The sender experiment identifies the causal effect of incentives on generated content, not merely correlations between writers' style and content quality.

4.2 What identifies the receiver effects

- Receivers are randomly assigned to summaries written under different incentive regimes.
- Some experiments remove click choice entirely, measuring pure knowledge conditional on exposure.
- Other experiments allow clicks and measure attention allocation.
- Recall experiments test whether the content is remembered differently when summaries are no longer visible.

Interpretation: The design separates supply of content from receiver attention. This is the main strength of the paper: it measures both stages of information transmission.

4.3 Why the click design is useful

- In standard online data, people who click differ from people who do not click.
- The experiment uses probabilistic implementation: a receiver’s chosen click can be implemented, but sometimes the computer randomly selects content.
- This helps separate preferences for clicking from the causal effect of detailed information exposure.

Interpretation: The click design makes the attention-information trade-off measurable: attention incentives raise the probability of information demand, but non-clickers remain exposed only to thinner summaries.

4.4 Why the paper is not just about misinformation

- The treatment does not significantly increase inaccurate-in-text units.
- The main content change is less accurate-in-text information and more not-in-text content.
- Misperceptions arise because summaries become vague, motivational, or implication-focused.

Interpretation: The paper shifts attention from falsehoods to omissions. Missing details can create biased beliefs even when the communicated statements are not explicitly false.

4.5 Limits and external validity

- The sender sample consists of freelance professionals, not journalists or social media users with reputational histories.
- Scientific communication is only one domain; political communication may behave differently.
- The experiment studies a first stage of communication from informed sender to receiver, not the full cascade of sharing and reinterpretation.
- The paper ethically avoids exposing receivers to harmful anti-vaccine or harmful-health behavior messages, so some real-world harms may be outside the experimental domain.

Interpretation: The experiment is strong on internal validity, but real online ecosystems may amplify or dampen these mechanisms through reputation, platform algorithms, and repeated sharing.

5 Tables and figures

This section keeps the original visual evidence close to the interpretation. Neighboring figures and tables are grouped to save space and improve reading speed. All visuals are directly cropped from the paper.

5.1 Figure 1 and Figure 2: source articles and receiver design

Read:

- Figure 1 lists the eight source articles, their topics, main findings, samples, methods, and conclusions.
- The articles cover cancer, sleep, vaccines, and climate.

- Figure 2 shows the receiver design: no-click conditions measure summary-based knowledge, while click conditions allow access to materials and measure materials-based or overall knowledge.
- The design distinguishes summaries available from summaries recalled, allowing the paper to measure immediate knowledge and memory-based knowledge.

Economic message: The paper’s empirical strategy depends on controlled source materials and controlled receiver exposure. Figure 1 establishes ground truth; Figure 2 shows how information transmission is decomposed into summary knowledge, click demand, and materials knowledge.

Topic	Reference	Main finding	Sample	Analysis	Conclusions
1 Cancer	Kim et al. (2019)	Individuals with diets high in vitamin A have a 17% lower risk of squamous cell carcinoma (SCC), a form of skin cancer, than those with low vitamin A consumption.	Nurses’ health (obs. = 121,700) and health professionals follow-up (obs. = 51,529) studies	Cohort study, longitudinal	The study authors suggest that the next step would be to conduct a clinical trial to test whether higher intake of vitamin A reduces the risk of SCC.
2 Cancer	Lee et al. (2019)	A molecule (I3C) in cruciferous vegetables reduces tumor growth because it inactivates a gene found in many cancers, the WWP1 gene.	Cancer-prone mice and human cells	Laboratory study	Individuals should not change their diets yet, as too large amounts of cruciferous vegetables (over six pounds a day) would be needed to prevent cancer.
3 Sleep	Gangwisch et al. (2020)	A diet high in glycemic index is associated with higher odds of insomnia among postmenopausal women.	Women’s health initiative observational study, baseline (obs. = 77,869) and follow-up (obs. = 53,069), on postmenopausal women	Cohort study, longitudinal	The authors suspect that reducing refined carbohydrates in one’s diet may be a low-cost way of preventing insomnia, but RCTs are needed.
4 Sleep	Perrault et al. (2019)	Participants fell asleep faster and had better memory the next day when sleeping on a rocking bed compared to a stationary bed.	18 healthy young adults	Laboratory study, within-subjects	Rocking is important for sleep quality and memory consolidation.
5 Vaccine	Mina et al. (2019)	Measles leads unvaccinated children to lose up to 75% of their protective antibodies for other diseases.	77 unvaccinated children in a community in the Netherlands	Event study, using ViScan to test blood samples	Measles vaccination is important to protect children from measles and other diseases.
6 Vaccine	Hviid et al. (2019)	The MMR vaccine is not associated with autism.	Danish population registry (obs. = 657,461) children born in 1999–2010	Cohort study, longitudinal	Showing no association between the MMR vaccine and autism is important due to increase in vaccine hesitancy and measles outbreaks in Europe.
7 Climate	Maxwell et al. (2019)	Deforestation of intact tropical forests has a 626% stronger impact on carbon emissions than previously estimated.	Intact forest loss from 2000 to 2013	Computational	Intact forest retention needs to receive more attention and more funding from initiatives such as REDD+.
8 Climate	Berzaghi et al. (2019)	Forest elephants affect tree growth and aboveground biomass and, thereby, affect the carbon emissions of forests.	Field measurements in the Congo Basin in forests affected by elephants and in forests in which they had been eradicated	Field measures and computer simulations	Forest elephants should receive more protection and expand to help fight climate change.

FIGURE 1. ARTICLES

(a) Figure 1: Articles.

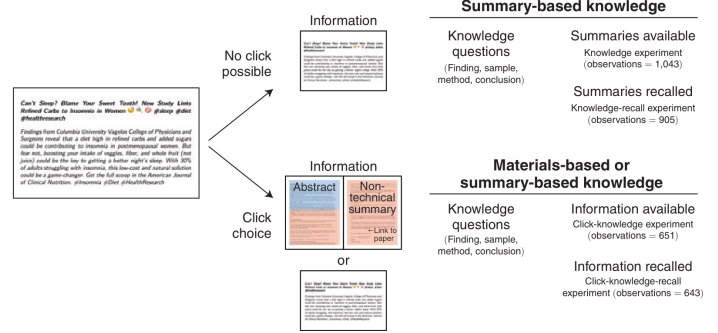


FIGURE 2. DESIGN OF RECEIVER EXPERIMENTS—KNOWLEDGE MEASUREMENT

(b) Figure 2: Receiver-experiment design.

5.2 Figure 3 and Table 1: effects on sender summaries

Read:

- Figure 3 shows that clickbait and viral incentives reduce the accuracy index and focus index, while increasing the style index.
- Accurate-in-text content falls, while not-in-text content rises.
- Method and finding content fall; introduction and calls to action rise.
- Table 1 reports the index estimates: clickbait lowers the accuracy index by 0.308 SD and focus index by 0.305 SD, while raising the style index by 0.402 SD.
- Viral incentives lower the accuracy index by 0.375 SD and focus index by 0.454 SD, while raising the style index by 0.676 SD.

Economic message: Attention incentives do not mainly create more explicit falsehoods. They create shorter, more attention-grabbing, less detailed communication.

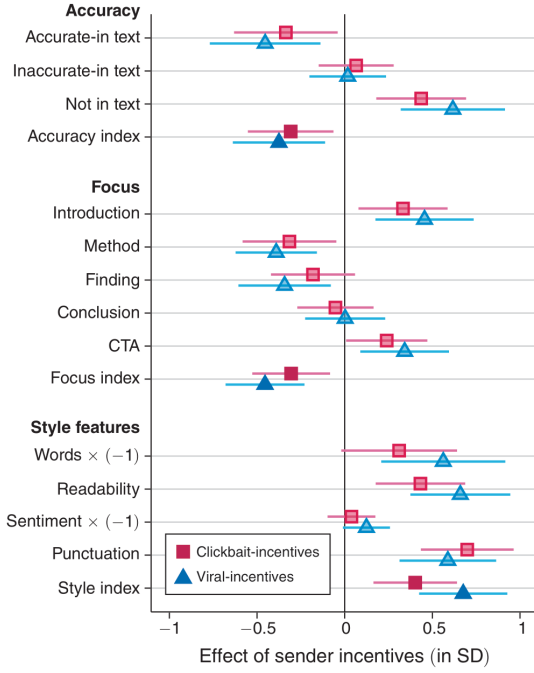


FIGURE 3. AVERAGE EFFECT OF SENDER INCENTIVES ON MESSAGE PRODUCTION

(a) Figure 3: Sender incentive effects.

TABLE 1—INCENTIVE EFFECTS ON SENDER SUMMARIES

	Accuracy index (1)	Focus index (2)	Style index (3)
Clickbait-incentives	-0.308 (0.124) [0.010]	-0.305 (0.112) [0.008]	0.402 (0.121) [0.004]
Viral-incentives	-0.375 (0.133) [0.002]	-0.454 (0.114) [0.001]	0.676 (0.127) [0.001]
Constant	-0.378 (0.193)	0.584 (0.149)	-0.669 (0.173)
Observations	595	595	595

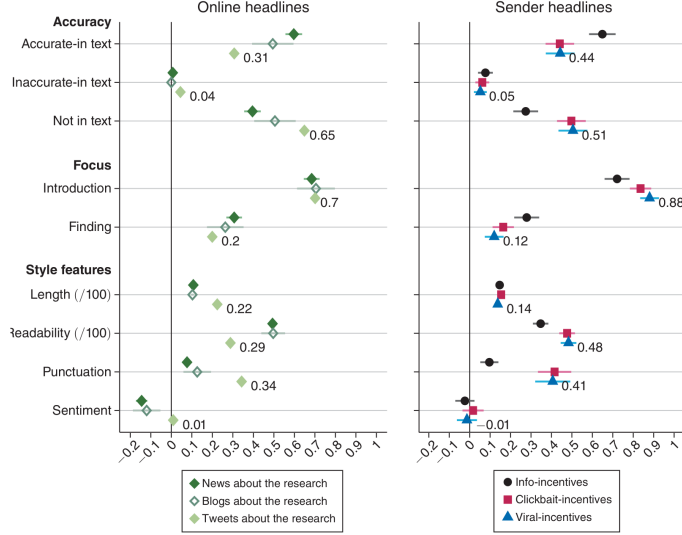
(b) Table 1: Sender summary outcomes.

5.3 Figure 4 and Figure 5: online headlines and LLM senders

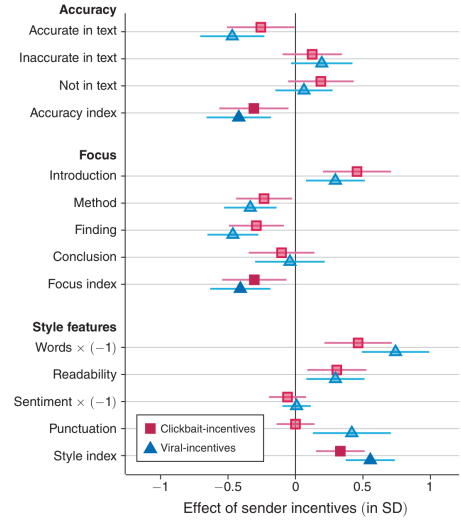
Read:

- Figure 4 compares naturally occurring online headlines with experimental sender headlines.
- Sender headlines under clickbait and viral incentives look similar to online mentions in their focus on introductions, style, and limited methodological detail.
- Figure 5 repeats the sender experiment with an LLM. The GPT-generated summaries show qualitatively similar patterns: lower accuracy/focus indices and higher attention-grabbing style.

Economic message: The professional-sender results are not isolated artifacts. Naturally occurring online communication and LLM-generated summaries display related attention-oriented patterns.



(a) Figure 4: Headline features.



(b) Figure 5: LLM sender effects.

5.4 Table 2 and Figure 6: receiver knowledge and clicks

Read:

- Table 2 shows that clickbait summaries reduce summary-based knowledge by 5.5 percentage points when summaries are available; viral summaries reduce it by 6.8 percentage points.
- Clickbait summaries raise click rates by 5.0 percentage points; viral summaries raise click rates by 4.1 percentage points.
- Overall knowledge falls for viral incentives by 6.2 percentage points when knowledge is available, while clickbait has a smaller overall effect.
- Figure 6 shows that the distribution of summary-based knowledge under Info-incentives stochastically dominates the clickbait and viral distributions.
- The largest drops appear for knowledge about sample and method, exactly the content categories that attention incentives reduce in sender summaries.

Economic message: Attention incentives increase demand for more information, but they lower knowledge for receivers who only read the summaries. The knowledge loss is concentrated in scientific details.

TABLE 2—KNOWLEDGE AND CLICKS: SUMMARY-LEVEL RESULTS

	Summary-based knowledge		Click rate (3)	Materials-based knowledge		Overall knowledge	
	Avail. (1)	Recall (2)		Avail. (4)	Recall (5)	Avail. (6)	Recall (7)
Clickbait-incentives	-0.055 (0.013) [0.001]	-0.028 (0.015) [0.078]	0.050 (0.012) [0.001]	0.013 (0.023) [0.197]	-0.030 (0.025) [0.112]	-0.028 (0.013) [0.063]	-0.024 (0.013) [0.078]
Viral-incentives	-0.068 (0.013) [0.001]	-0.021 (0.015) [0.075]	0.041 (0.012) [0.002]	-0.043 (0.026) [0.071]	-0.042 (0.025) [0.071]	-0.062 (0.013) [0.001]	-0.025 (0.012) [0.040]
Constant	0.374 (0.018)	0.330 (0.022)	0.350 (0.020)	0.785 (0.029)	0.565 (0.034)	0.507 (0.019)	0.417 (0.020)
Observations	595	589	595	395	451	595	595
Info-incentives: mean	0.57	0.49	0.20	0.82	0.64	0.62	0.53
Info-incentives: SD	0.18	0.17	0.12	0.19	0.21	0.15	0.14

Notes: This table displays the estimated coefficients from linear regressions on (i) summary-based knowledge when the summary is available (knowledge experiment) and when it must be recalled and the preferred click choices of the receiver are implemented (knowledge-recall and click-knowledge-recall experiment, for summaries not clicked on, which due to random implementation results in $observations = 589$ being observed by receivers in this group) (columns 1 and 2); (ii) click rate (column 3); (iii) materials-based knowledge (for those whose preferred click choices were implemented), when the materials were seen by the receiver (click-knowledge experiment) and when they had to be recalled (click-knowledge-recall experiment) (columns 4 and 5)—note that, since ca. 6 percent of summaries were never clicked on and ca. 25 percent of click choices were not implemented, by design, the number of observations in columns 4 and 5 is lower; and (iv) overall knowledge (columns 6 and 7). Regressions include article fixed effects and sender characteristics. Sharpened FDR q -values are computed using the Anderson (2008) two-stage BKY procedure, over all outcomes in the table for a treatment, and shown in square brackets.

Table 2: Knowledge and clicks.

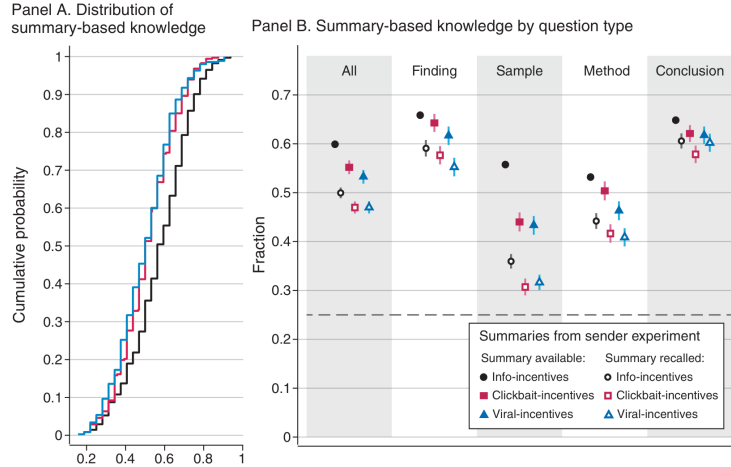


FIGURE 6. RECEIVER KNOWLEDGE WHEN EXPOSED TO SUMMARIES

Figure 6: Receiver knowledge when exposed to summaries.

5.5 Figure 7 and Figure 8: errors, beliefs, and intentions

Read:

- Figure 7 shows that receivers exposed to clickbait or viral summaries are more likely to believe the sample is more representative than it actually is.
- The effect on believing the sample is larger is smaller and not central.
- Figure 8 shows that clickbait summaries increase the intentions index: receivers become more likely to encourage behavior change, indicate intended own behavior change, or infer doctor recommendations.
- Viral summaries are directionally similar but less statistically strong in the beliefs-and-intentions experiment.

Economic message: Missing information can change beliefs about external validity and behavioral implications. The mechanism is not only lower knowledge, but biased interpretation of what the research implies.

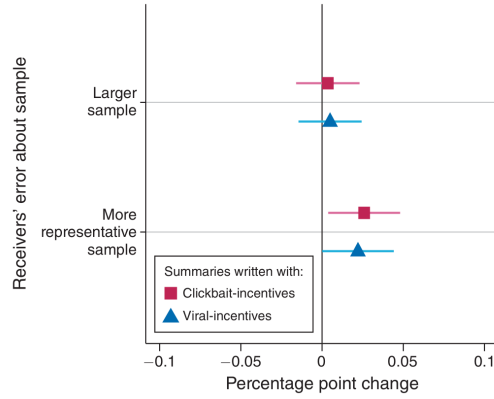


FIGURE 7. RECEIVER ERRORS

(a) Figure 7: Receiver errors.

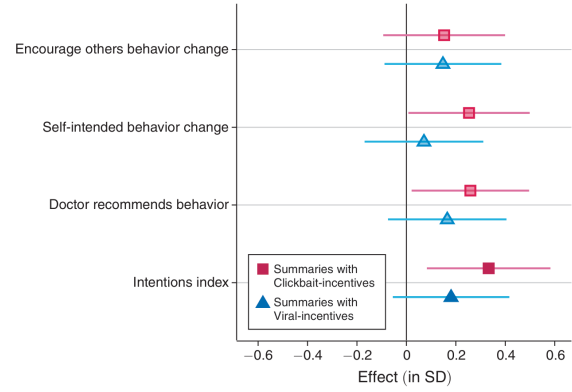


FIGURE 8. RECEIVER BELIEFS AND INTENTIONS

(b) Figure 8: Beliefs and intentions.

5.6 Figure 9: heterogeneity in attention and knowledge

Read:

- Panel A shows a negative relationship between click rates and summary-based knowledge.
- A 1 percentage point increase in click rate is associated with about a 0.3 percentage point decrease in summary-based knowledge.
- Panel B shows that once clicked materials are included, the negative relationship between click rates and overall knowledge largely disappears.
- There is substantial heterogeneity: some summaries attract many clicks while others receive almost none.

Economic message: High-attention content can be low-information at the summary stage. However, if the summary successfully induces a click, the additional materials can offset part of the knowledge loss.

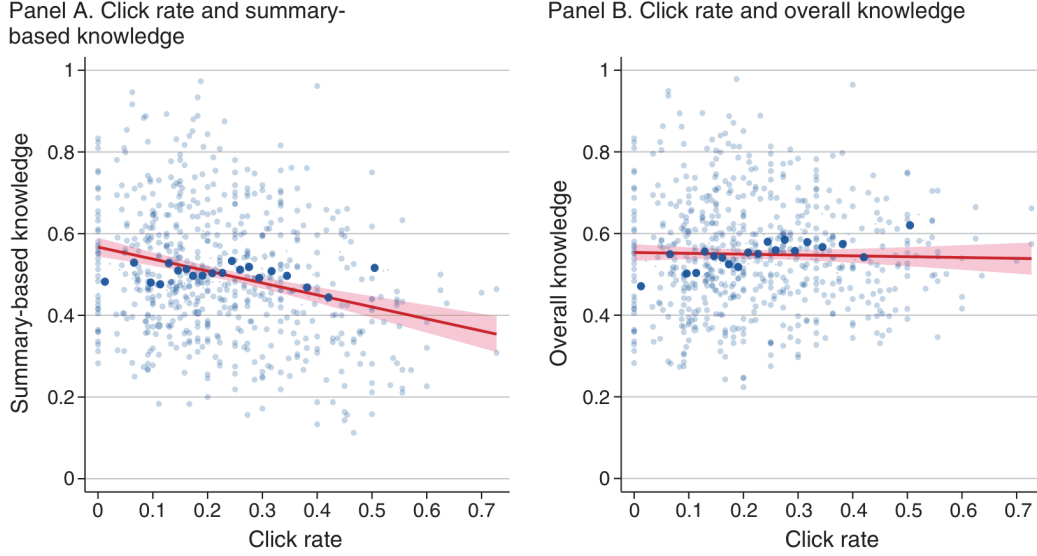


FIGURE 9. HETEROGENEITY IN RECEIVERS' ATTENTION AND KNOWLEDGE

Figure 9: Heterogeneity in receivers' attention and knowledge.

6 Short summary

- The paper studies how incentives to attract online attention affect information transmission.
- It runs a sender experiment with 149 freelance professionals and 595 summaries about scientific findings.
- Senders are randomized into Info, Clickbait, and Viral incentive treatments.
- Attention incentives reduce accurate-in-text information and increase not-in-text content.
- Attention incentives do not significantly increase explicitly inaccurate-in-text content.
- Summaries under attention incentives contain less method and finding information and more introduction, implication, and call-to-action content.
- They also become shorter, more readable, and more attention-grabbing in style.
- Receiver experiments show that summary-based knowledge falls under attention incentives.
- Click rates rise, which can partly offset knowledge losses for receivers who demand more information.
- Most receivers do not click, so many remain exposed only to less informative summaries.
- Missing information can create biased beliefs about whether a sample is representative and whether findings imply behavior change.
- The paper's most important channel is not direct falsehood; it is omission, vagueness, and relevance-focused framing.
- LLM-generated summaries under attention incentives show qualitatively similar patterns.
- The main takeaway is that attention markets can produce misperceptions even without increasing explicit factual errors.

7 Conclusion

7.1 Core conclusion

Serra-Garcia shows that attention incentives change the supply of information and the demand for information at the same time. The same summaries that attract more clicks transmit less scientific detail to people who only read the summary. This creates an attention-information trade-off.

7.2 Economic intuition

To attract attention, senders make summaries easier, shorter, more motivational, and more relevant to readers. This makes receivers more curious and increases click demand. But it also strips away details about samples, methods, and limitations. When receivers do not click, they use a thinner information set and may overinfer what the research shows.

7.3 Takeaway

The paper identifies a missing-information channel for misperceptions. Online content need not be explicitly false to mislead. Omitting scientific details and emphasizing relevance can generate biased beliefs about representativeness, prescriptions, and behavioral implications.